After I checked into the Biltmore, George Ward, one of Bill Meiklejohn's assistants, warned me that it might take weeks or months for Warner Brothers to cast me in a movie because it had a large stable of new stock players who'd be competing with me for roles.

He was wrong. I was playing in my first movie within a few days, but not before I'd played a spectator's role in an offscreen drama that might have been called *The Remaking of Dutch Reagan*.

Thank goodness they liked my voice, for whatever reason, because for a while it seemed that was about all they liked about me.

First stop: Makeup.

"The hair has to be changed," Max Arnow told a hairstylist.

The hairstylist looked at me the way a paleontologist might examine a newly discovered but as yet unidentified fossil plucked from a prehistoric riverbed.

"Where did you get that haircut?" she asked me.

"It looks like somebody cut it with bowl number seven," she added, before I could answer.

I still had my Harold Teen haircut—short and parted down the middle.

Then they announced I had another problem: My head was too small.

"Where did you get that coat?" Arnow demanded, giving a fish-eye once-over to a new sport coat I'd purchased solely to impress him. "You can't wear that outfit. The shoulders are too big. *They make your head look too small."*

Next stop: Wardrobe.

"See what you can do about his head," Arnow told a wardrobe designer.

A tailor stripped off my coat and committed murder on it, slashing the shoulders and ruthlessly whacking away pleats and tucks.